

CORE FORMULA

Situation -> Complication -> Question -> Answer -> Situation: where things stand. **Complication:** what has changed or gone wrong. **Question:** the decision it forces. **Answer:** what you recommend. -> **Minimum viable move:** Situation X. Complication Y. Question: what should we do? Answer: Z. -> **Worked example:** "We shipped on time (S). But support tickets have doubled (C). Do we pause new features to fix it (Q)? I'd pause for two weeks (A)." -> **Field rule:** use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say it in four short beats — the situation, the one complication that actually matters, the question it forces, and your answer — then speak it like a person, not a template.

BEST FOR

- Briefings and status updates
- Proposals and recommendations
- Strategy narratives and presentations
- Framing a problem before a decision
- Making a scattered thought concise
- Emails that need to be scannable

PHRASE BANK

Quick frames · Openers

- "Here's where we are, here's the snag, here's what I'd do."
- "Short version: the setup, the catch, then my answer."
- "One situation, one problem, one recommendation — quickly."
- "Let me give you the frame first, then the detail."
- "Give me thirty seconds to lay it out cleanly."
- "Context, complication, then the call."
- "The point up front, the reasoning after — sound alright?"

Briefings & proposals · Work / meetings / email

- "Where we are: [situation]. What's changed: [complication]. The question this raises: [question]. My recommendation: [answer]."
- "The situation's stable; the complication is the deadline; so the question is whether we cut scope; I think we should."
- "Two lines of background, then the decision we actually need to make."
- "I'll set the scene, flag the risk, and put my recommendation at the end."
- "For the email: a short paragraph of context, one of the problem, then the ask in bold."
- "The headline is the answer; everything above it is just how I got there."
- "Here's the background you need, and here's the call I'm asking you to make."
- "Let me frame the problem before I bring the recommendation."

Landing the question · Making the ask explicit

- "The real question here is this one — not the ten smaller ones around it."
- "So the decision in front of us is whether we [do X]."
- "Given all that, here's what I'd do."
- "My answer is [X]; happy to walk back through the reasoning if it helps."

- "The one thing I need from you is a yes or no on [X]."
- "Let me name the actual question before we go any further."
- "That's the situation and the snag — so what should we do about it?"

Structure with warmth · Check before you organise

- "Can I lay this out in a structured way, or would you rather just talk it through?"
- "I've got a tidy version of this — tell me if that's useful or too neat."
- "Before I organise it, is a clear summary what you're after right now?"
- "I'll keep it simple: here's the situation, here's the catch, here's my thought."
- "Let me make this easy to follow rather than dumping it all at once."
- "If the structure gets in the way, stop me and I'll just say it plainly."
- "I want this to be clear for you, not polished for me."

When it lands badly · Softening / recovery

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "That came out like a presentation — here's what I actually mean."
- "Forget the framework for a second. The honest version is this."
- "I think I over-organised that. What did you actually need from me?"

Pressure & sensitive rooms · Conflict / distress / guarded

- "There's a lot here, so let me keep it to one clear point at a time."
- "I'll say the situation, then the problem, then stop so we can talk."
- "Before any structure — I know this one matters, so tell me what you need first."
- "One sentence each, then I'll pause: this is the situation; this is what's gone wrong."
- "I'm not trying to manage you with a framework — I just want us clear on the problem."
- "Let me name the real problem plainly, without dressing it up."
- "The situation's hard and the complication's real — I'd rather work out the question together than hand you an answer."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Using SCQA as a visible script and sounding rehearsed.

Better: Using SCQA silently to organise a concise response.

Best: Using SCQA flexibly, then checking whether the listener is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — answer first, structure only if they ask for it.

""Short answer: pause for two weeks. I can give you the why if you want it.""

If The listener needs support

Validate first and delay the framework until the emotion settles.

""That's a lot to carry. Tell me what you need before I get into the detail.""

If The listener needs a story or example

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

""Let me give you a concrete example of how this played out.""

If The listener needs to act

End with one clean, specific next step.

""So the one thing I need is a yes or no on cutting reporting.""

If You notice you're inflating the problem

Drop the drama and name the issue at its true size.

""Honestly it's a small thing, but worth a heads-up.""

If The listener is already clear

Stop structuring — don't force the remaining steps.

""Sounds like you've got it. I'll leave it there.""

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make a scattered contribution concise and memorable — one line per step. — *""Here's where we are, here's the snag, here's the call, here's what I'd do.""*

Email or written update

Put each step in a short labelled paragraph or bullet so the reader can scan it. — *""Background: ? / What's changed: ? / Decision needed: ? / My recommendation: ?""*

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback is wanted before you structure it. — *""Do you want my read on it, or just a sounding board? If it's useful, here's the shape of it.""*

Difficult conversation

One sentence per step, then pause so it stays a conversation. — *""Here's the situation. Here's what's gone wrong. Can we work out the question together?""*

Someone is upset

Validate first; only structure once they feel heard. — *""That sounds really frustrating. When you're ready, I can lay out where things stand.""*

Pitching a proposal

Lead from shared context to your recommendation without hiding the ask. — *""We agreed on the goal; here's the obstacle; here's the question; here's what I'd back.""*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The issue is simple and needs no framing
- The listener needs speed and you are withholding the answer
- Emotion is high and validation should come first
- You would be inflating a minor issue into false drama
- The other person needs to be heard, not organised
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the shape

Pick one briefing or email you receive today and label its Situation, Complication, Question and Answer — or note which of the four is missing.

Day 2 — Write one

Take a real work issue and write a 60-second response that moves through all four steps.

Day 3 — Cut it down

Cut yesterday's response by a third — to about 30 seconds — without losing the core point.

Day 4 — Say it two ways

Say it aloud once as visible structure and once as plain speech. Keep the plainer version.

Day 5 — Make the question explicit

Take three updates you'd normally give and add one sentence to each that names the actual decision it forces.

Day 6 — Use it live, lightly

In one real conversation, use SCQA without announcing it, then watch whether the listener gets clearer or more able to act.

Day 7 — Practise the recovery

Deliberately over-structure something, then practise a recovery line that drops the frame and says the point plainly.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use SCQA to serve the listener, or to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Was the complication real, or manufactured for effect?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve autonomy and dignity?